

PERSONAL COMMUNITY

John O'Brien & Beth Mount. Make a difference: A guidebook for person-centered direct support. inclusion.com.

As you continue to support people to live fulfilling lives within their communities, it is essential to identify what experiences and accomplishments will increase their sense of freedom, membership, and belonging. In this session you will be introduced to the construct of the Five Valued Experiences. The experiences highlighted will support others in developing a sense of belonging, emphasizing each person's unique talents and capabilities.

All citizens have better life outcomes, and everyone's world grows more interesting, when communities offer rich opportunities for people to have these five valued experiences:

- **Belonging** in a diverse variety of relationships and memberships.
- **Being respected** as whole persons, whose history, capacities and futures are worthy of attention and whose gifts engage them in valued social roles.
- **Sharing ordinary places** and activities with other citizens, neighbors, classmates, and co-workers. Living, working, learning, and playing confidently in ordinary community settings.
- **Contributing** by discovering, developing, and giving their gifts and investing their capacities and energy in pursuits that make a positive difference to other people. There are gifts of being and gifts of doing: contributions can include interested presence as well as capable performance. Contributions may be freely exchanged (volunteered) or earn pay.
- **Choosing** what they want in everyday situations in ways that reflect their highest purpose. Having the freedom, support, information, and assistance to make the same choices as others of a similar age and learning to make wiser choices over time. Being encouraged to use and strengthen their voice regardless of mode of communication, clarify what really matters, make thoughtful decisions, and learn from experiences.

Explore gifts, skills and capacities, what a person is good at and what qualities the person has to contribute. Think about situations where the person can make a contribution to others and identify next steps.

Invite the person to talk about a time when something they did made a positive difference for others and gave the person a "good feeling." Build on this with stories from others who know them well about when the person is at their best. Consider what this tells us about the person's gifts, skills, and contributions.

Here is a construct that defines different gifts and capacities:

Gifts of the hand (and feet and voice) are abilities and skills that a person can contribute:

- dancing, singing, acting.
- typing, drawing, arranging shapes and colors, decorating
- using a computer.
- composing music, sewing.
- working hard, using physical strength.
- ability to sign, ability to speak or understand another language.

Gifts of the head include the knowledge, questions, experience, and information that a person can contribute:

- figuring people out, organizing and classifying things.
- travel routes, sports news, fan information, gossip.
- local history, trivia.
- creative thinking, math, solving puzzles.
- interest in politics, desire to think and talk about big questions

Gifts of history and identity include the experiences, knowledge, duties, responsibility concerns, types of belonging that come with membership in a family, religion, national or ethnic group, citizenship, or member of a club:

- Taking care of others as the oldest sibling
- Faith and Community Service

Gifts of the heart are the interests, enthusiasms, personal passions, and the rewards of relationship that someone brings to others:

- welcoming people, patience, courage, impatience to move from talk into action.
- sensitivity to others, high energy, desire for order, ability to listen.
- passion for justice, love of nature, ability to draw others out, spiritual gifts.

PLACES AND POSSIBILITIES

Identify the places that matter in a person's life. This increases understanding and helps identify places that are worth paying more attention to. Identify all the places a person goes that are important to them. Explore the role that the person has in each place. Think about places where the person's gifts and capacities might be welcomed and valued. Explore how this information can help in strengthening existing connections or where new connections can be made. Ask:

- Where is the person a customer?
- Where is the person a member?
- Where does the person feel at their best?

Use the answers to these questions to expand the community of the person by asking:

- Where else might the person's gifts and capacities be welcomed'?
- Where might existing connections be strengthened?
- Where might new connections be made?

WHAT MORE IS POSSIBLE?

The "What More Is Possible" spiral, developed by John O'Brien and Beth Mount, is a journey of discovering new opportunities and possibilities for people, especially those with intellectual disabilities, to live a meaningful life. It centers on finding better ways to support people to live within their community, ensuring they get the support they truly want and need.

We do this by asking ourselves; what more do I want to ask of myself and my allies and how might I make a positive impact in people's lives, as we move along the journey to reach belonging and membership. Imagine this journey as a spiral, starting at the center:

- We begin by getting to know the person on a deeper level, focusing on uncovering their skills and interests. This involves reflection on our own part and evaluating the support we offer, which ultimately reveals the person's capabilities and passions. Once these are identified, we act on what we learned and adjust our supports, thus leading to better supports and services.
- As we journey to the second spiral; we ask ourselves to go beyond just personal support. It focuses on helping a person be part of their community in a meaningful way. Not only asking more of ourselves, the supports that we offer, but of our community. Thus, creating new opportunities to explore where community connections may exist. Adjusting our supports to foster connection and contribution.

- The third spiral goes even further. It's about thinking bigger and asking, "How can I make a positive impact on my whole community?" This means looking at the community as a whole, its strengths, and problems, and finding ways for people with disabilities to make meaningful contributions and partnerships within the community. The spiral shows us that there are different levels of opportunity and change. Each level asks more of the person and the support they have. It also asks more of the community to be inclusive and provide opportunities for everyone.